thoughtful and innovative coach, who now runs the Essex second team and Academy.

He was released as a player at the end of the 2003 season, by which time I'd been given three first-team games on relatively flat pitches. I made 84 in a win over Surrey, contributed two more half-centuries to average 47.80, but learned most from the example of two players from diverse backgrounds and abilities.

I watched Waqar Younis become a different player when he sensed victory, shifting up several gears to bowl fast reverse swing, take five wickets and mop up the win. I studied Andy Flower from the other end at the Oval, when he made 201, and listened to him distil common sense and experience. He was thirty-five, in the final game of a relegation season, and his application was absolute.

I was growing up, on and off the pitch. I moved away from home and learned on the job. During one defeat by Hampshire, I'd got out to a massive hack against James Bruce, the right-arm fast-medium bowler who would retire prematurely in 2007 to take up a job in the City of London.

My error was compounded by the fact that it was the final ball of Bruce's spell. I should have stayed around to see him off. I was headstrong, an aspiring, adolescent pro, who thought he knew best. I was right in the first-team mix, desperate to make my way. This was my living, and I was beginning to realize that avoidable mistakes had consequences.

The boy had become a man, with rough edges and many more miles to travel.